

The CFO Lens

An audience-specific reading of the OIA Reference Model for chief financial officers and the finance organisations they lead.

By Mark Templeton · Part of the OIA Lens System · Draft v0.1 · 2026 · Published by the Agentics Foundation

Anticipated lens — draft for author review. The Lens System v0.3 names the CFO Lens as a future lens to be published “as practitioner engagement and demand support.” This draft is authored to the Lens System methodology (5–7 interpretive lenses across 2–3 orthogonal axes) ahead of formal publication; it should be reviewed and pressure-tested before it is treated as canonical.

1. What this document is

The OIA Reference Model describes the structural shape of enterprise intelligent systems — ten layers, seven cross-layer spans, three defining properties, four named threat surfaces — written to be vendor-neutral and audience-neutral. Most chief financial officers do not work from structural specifications; they work from capital-allocation frameworks, unit economics, and the categories their finance organisation reports against.

Without translation, the OIA never reaches the capital conversation it should inform.

This is the translation. The CFO Lens reads the same OIA architecture through the questions a finance leader is actually asking about the most capital-intensive enterprise technology investment of the decade. The architecture is invariant. The lens changes the language.

2. What is in the CFO planning conversation in 2026

Seven observations frame what the finance audience is engaging with today.

- **AI is the most capital-intensive technology investment in a decade**, and the commitment is being made faster than the finance categories can absorb.
- **CapEx-versus-OpEx no longer sorts cleanly**. Training is amortisable; inference is consumption-based; fine-tuning sits between — and the mix determines the P&L shape.
- **Supplier concentration is a financial risk, not just an architectural one**. GPU and model-provider concentration creates pricing power the enterprise does not control.
- **The unit economics of an agent are not yet a settled number**. Token costs, GPU-hours, and orchestration overhead must resolve into a cost-per-outcome the business can price against.
- **Working-capital and commitment structures are being locked in early**. Reserved capacity, prepaid credits, and multi-year commitments trade flexibility for price before demand is known.
- **Spend is fragmenting across business units** that each bought AI before finance had a governance model.
- **The board is asking finance to fund an AI strategy it can defend** — against a structural map, not a vendor list.

3. The six interpretive lenses on three axes

Capital axis · How AI is funded

AI as CapEx. *Know what is amortisable and what is not.* Training and owned infrastructure behave like

capital assets; the treatment shapes the P&L. Anchor: capital-budgeting practice.

AI as OpEx. *Govern consumption before it governs you.* Token and inference spend is consumption-based

and must be metered, forecast, and controlled. Anchor: **FinOps Foundation**.

Exposure axis · Where financial risk concentrates

AI as Concentration Risk. *Price the exposure to GPU and model-provider concentration.*

Supplier pricing

power is a working-capital and margin risk established at Layers 0–2. Anchor: enterprise risk management.

AI as Commitment. *Trade flexibility for price deliberately.* Reserved capacity and multi-year deals are financial instruments with optionality value. Anchor: procurement / treasury practice.

Value axis · What AI returns

AI as Unit Economics. *Resolve the cost-per-outcome of an agent.* Cost per task, per agent, per decision

— against a structural map, not a blended average. Anchor: unit-economics / activity-based costing.

AI as Portfolio. *Allocate across the stack, not across vendors.* Capital allocated by OIA layer and span, distinguishing partner-territory from own-stack investment. Anchor: capital-allocation frameworks.

4. The four threat surfaces as financial exposures

The four named threat surfaces translate, for finance, into loss events, insurable exposures, and contingency-reserve questions.

- **Mimicry** (Layer 9) — deepfake-authorised transactions are a direct fraud-loss exposure.
- **Agent-in-the-middle** (Layer 7) — an ungoverned orchestration boundary is an un-auditable financial control gap.
- **Agent spoofing** (Identity span) — inherited agent authority is an unbounded-liability exposure.
- **Model compromise** (Layer 5) — dependency on an externally mutable model is a continuity and impairment risk to capitalised AI assets.

5. The ten layers through the CFO Lens

Read as a capital-allocation map: **partner territory** (rent/consume) versus the **enterprise's own stack** (build/capitalise).

- **Layer 0 · Physical Compute** — *Partner*. “What is our exposure to energy and supply-chain cost, and is it capital or consumption?”
- **Layer 1 · Silicon Abstraction** — *Partner*. “What is our GPU-concentration exposure, and are we portable enough to keep pricing power?”

- **Layer 2 · Sovereign Infrastructure** — *Partner*. “What does sovereignty cost as a premium, and where must we pay it?”
- **Layer 3 · Agent Data Substrate** — *Own stack*. “What are we capitalising in our data substrate, and what is its ongoing cost to govern?”
- **Layer 4 · Model Training and Adaptation** — *Partner-leaning*. “Build, fine-tune, or rent — and what is amortisable in each?”
- **Layer 5 · Inference and Retrieval** — *Shared*. “What is our inference run-rate, and is it forecastable per outcome?”
- **Layer 6 · Context and Knowledge** — *Own stack*. “What does our retrieval/context capability cost to build and maintain?”
- **Layer 7 · Orchestration and Workflow** — *Own stack*. “What is the fully-loaded cost of an agent, including orchestration overhead?”
- **Layer 8 · Continuity Fabric** — *Own stack*. “What is the cost of NOT owning continuity — the impairment and recovery exposure?”
- **Layer 9 · Human and Browser Interface** — *Own stack*. “What is our fraud-loss exposure at the human/agent boundary?”

6. Adopting the lens

- **As a capital-allocation lens** — the layers and the partner/own-stack split give finance a structural map for AI capital, replacing vendor-list budgeting.
- **As a board and audit surface** — a defensible way to articulate AI spend, exposure, and unit economics.
- **As a vendor-negotiation vocabulary** — locating supplier pricing power at specific layers and spans.

The Foundation invites the finance community to engage with the lens, push back on what does not fit, and contribute to its refinement.